

TWO MEN, ONE GOSPEL

Demas, Luke, and the Question of First Love

30-Minute Sermon Draft — Working Script for Delivery

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Delivery notes appear in [BRACKETS LIKE THIS]. This script is written to be spoken, not read. Read it aloud during preparation — the rhythm matters.

OPENING — The Last Roll Call

[3 minutes]

I want to begin in a room.

Rome. Not the Rome of piazzas and tourists — the Rome of Nero. Cold dungeons. Midnight arrests. Christians who disappeared. Approximately AD 67.

Paul is in his second Roman imprisonment. Not house arrest this time. A cell. Execution is close enough that he knows it. He writes what will be his last letter. And near the end of that letter, he does something simple and devastating: he takes attendance.

[READ SLOWLY — do not rush this:]

"For Demas hath forsaken me, having loved this present world, and is departed unto Thessalonica... Only Luke is with me."

[Pause. Let it sit. Then:]

Two names. Two men. Same mission field. Same pressures. Same world pulling at both of them.

One drifted. One stayed.

The difference was not talent. Not theological knowledge. Not even the outward appearance of faith.

The difference was the location of their love.

That is the whole sermon. Everything I say this morning is an expansion of that sentence.

I. THE BIBLICAL GROUND — Reading the Arc

[5 minutes]

Demas appears exactly three times in the New Testament. And the arc of those three appearances is the argument.

First: Philemon 1:24. Paul lists his circle. Among them: "*Demas, my fellow laborer.*" Fellow laborer. Trusted. Named. Present. Inside the tent.

Second: Colossians 4:14. Same period. Paul closes a letter to Colossae: "*Luke the beloved physician, and Demas, greet you.*" Still there. Still named alongside Luke. No asterisk. No warning.

Third: 2 Timothy 4:10. Years later. Paul's final letter. One sentence: "*For Demas hath forsaken me, having loved this present world.*"

Gone.

[Pause again. Then:]

Now here is what the Greek tells us — and I want to spend just a moment here, because the word Paul chooses is precise.

The word translated "loved" is *agapas* — the aorist of *agapa*. That is the word of John 3:16: "God so *loved* the world." That is the word of the Great Commandment: "thou shalt *love* the Lord thy God." That is the word Jesus uses when he stands on the shore and asks Peter three times: "Simon, lovest thou me?"

Paul does not say Demas feared the world, or enjoyed the world, or chose the world under pressure. He says Demas *loved* it. He applied to the passing age the very word that belongs to God.

And the arc is the warning. Between Philemon and 2 Timothy, nothing dramatic happened. No recorded crisis. No dramatic apostasy. He simply... drifted. Quietly. Incrementally. Until the distance became irreversible.

This was not an acute event. This was a chronic condition of the soul.

II. THE ANATOMY OF DRIFT

[8 minutes]

Let me be a physician for a moment.

In medicine, we distinguish between acute and chronic conditions. A heart attack announces itself — chest pain, diaphoresis, the sudden certainty that something catastrophic has happened. No one misses it.

But coronary artery disease — the underlying process — is silent. Plaque builds over decades. Vessels narrow. The heart compensates. A person can have severe, life-limiting disease and feel entirely well, because the deterioration has been so gradual that the body has adapted around it.

Demas did not have an acute spiritual event. He had a chronic condition of the soul.

I want to name three symptoms. Not to be diagnostic for its own sake — but because if we can name what happened to him, we have a fighting chance of seeing it in ourselves.

Symptom 1: Urgency fades to background music.

Demas heard Paul preach. He heard the eschatological urgency: *Christ is coming. The present world is passing away.* He believed it — for a while. But somewhere in the years between Philemon and 2 Timothy, *soon* became *eventually*. The present age, which was supposed to feel temporary, started to feel permanent. And when the world stops feeling temporary, you start optimizing for it.

When did you last feel the urgency you felt the first time you understood what the gospel actually meant?

Symptom 2: Good work replaces first love.

Demas went to Thessalonica. Not to vacation. To work. Thessalonica was a city with a church Paul had founded — there was ministry to be done there.

Demas did not stop working for God. He stopped being with God.

Ellen White saw this pattern clearly: *"Many are so absorbed in business that they have no time for prayer, no time for the study of the Bible... The cares of this life crowd out the things of eternity."* — *Testimonies*, Vol. 5, p. 161.

She does not say "the love of evil." She says "the cares of this life." Good things. Necessary things. Things that crowd.

[Staccato. Deliver slowly:]

The most dangerous spiritual condition is not rebellion.

It is comfortable productivity with a cold heart.

Symptom 3: The love question has no substitute.

In John 21, Jesus comes to Peter on the shore after the resurrection. He does not give Peter a performance review. He does not ask about evangelism numbers, prayer metrics, doctrinal accuracy. He asks one question. Three times.

"Simon, lovest thou me?"

Not: Do you work for me? Serve me? Attend for me? Love.

And Christ says the same to the church at Ephesus — a church that worked harder than any other in the seven letters of Revelation. Active. Doctrinally sound. Persevering. And Christ says: *"Nevertheless I have somewhat against thee, because thou hast left thy first love."*

What would you struggle to surrender if Christ asked for it this week? Not what you know you should surrender — what you actually love.

III. THE ANATOMY OF FIDELITY — Luke

[7 minutes]

Now I want to turn from Demas to Luke.

Luke was a physician. In the first-century Roman world, that meant education, professional options, and genuine mobility. He could have secured a patron, established a practice anywhere in the empire, and done meaningful work without ever setting foot near a condemned prisoner.

He chose the prison cell.

"Only Luke is with me."

Three things explain his fidelity. Three things held where Demas's did not.

First: Luke wrote himself out of his own narrative.

Read Luke and Acts carefully. He is present in the "we" passages — *"we sailed," "we stayed"* — but his name never appears. Not once. He documents faithfully and then disappears from the sentence.

He was not building his own story. He was recording Someone else's.

That disposition — self-subordination rather than self-erasure — is what holds under pressure. When the mission field no longer serves your narrative, the temptation is to find a mission field that does. Luke had no narrative to protect. He had already given it away.

Second: He practiced what he documented.

Luke recorded the parable of the Prodigal Son. He preserved the words: *"If any man will come after me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross daily."* He documented the theology of sacrifice.

And then he stayed in a prison cell with a man who was about to die.

There is a kind of integrity in Luke that we do not often name: the integrity between the theology he wrote and the life he chose. Ellen White writes in *Acts of the Apostles* that Luke's "services were a great comfort to Paul" — not merely professional services, but the presence of someone who had not been purchased by the easier option.

Third: He carried the "only."

Only Luke is with me.

The Greek word is *monos* — alone, solitary, the single one remaining. Not "mostly Luke." Not "especially Luke." *Only*.

Think about what that word meant to Paul in that cell. One man's presence became, in Paul's final hours, the entire embodiment of the body of Christ. Luke did not know that this three-word sentence would carry his name through twenty centuries of Christian reading. He stayed because staying was faithful.

And that is the invitation I am extending to you this morning: You never know when your staying will be someone's *only*.

There is someone — in this congregation, in your family, in the margin of your professional world — for whom your faithful presence is the *only*. You will not receive a plaque for it. The moment will probably not feel significant. But on the testimony of this text: Luke did not feel the weight of the "only" when he chose to stay. He only knew it in retrospect.

IV. THE INTERIOR TURN

[4 minutes] — [DO NOT RUSH OR CUT THIS SECTION]

Let me step out from behind the text for a moment.

I am a physician. I build things. I move fast across multiple domains — clinical medicine, administration, ministry, writing. And I am telling you — from personal testimony, not from a safe distance — that the Demas condition is not something I observe in other people and then come to warn you about.

It is something I feel.

Not toward obvious sin. Toward something quieter: the satisfaction of a productive week that had very little room for the actual presence of God. The week where the theology was correct — the Sabbath was kept, the sermon was prepared — and yet somewhere in the volume of good work, Christ had moved from the center of my love to the object of my professional attention.

That is the Demas condition. Not rebellion. Drift.

And if I can feel this pull — having spent years studying exactly this text, in exactly this tradition — then the pull is real for everyone in this room.

The question is not whether you have drifted. The question is whether you are honest enough to stop, this morning, and ask where you are standing right now.

Not where you plan to be. Not where you were. Right now. This Sabbath.

Where is your love?

V. THE PRESCRIPTION — Remember. Repent. Return.

[3 minutes]

The Laodicean letter does not end with diagnosis. The Ephesian letter does not end with condemnation. Christ addresses both with prescription — not punishment.

To Laodicea: *"I counsel thee to buy of me gold tried in the fire... anoint thine eyes with eyesalve, that thou mayest see."* The eyesalve of the Spirit restores two things: the ability to see Christ's beauty, and the ability to see your own need. Both are lost in the drift.

To Ephesus — and through Ephesus, to us — three commands.

Remember. Where were you when the fire was first lit? When the gospel broke through for the first time? Return to that memory — not as nostalgia, but as a measuring rod. The distance between who you were then and who you are now is the shape of the drift.

Repent. Not groveling. Turning. *Metanoē* — a change of direction. Turn back toward what you turned away from.

Return. Do the first works. Not different works. The first ones. The prayer that was conversation rather than obligation. The Scripture that was nourishment rather than material. The worship that was encounter rather than attendance.

CLOSE — Which Man Are You Becoming?

[Blends into the prescription — no hard stop]

The sermon is almost done. The trajectory is not.

You will leave this building today and return to the *aiōn* — the present age. The same age Demas loved. Your phone will notify you. Monday will present itself. And the world will resume making its case for why it deserves your deepest attention.

You will make choices. Small ones. Invisible to everyone around you. But they are, in aggregate, the answer to one question:

Which man am I becoming?

Not today — becoming. The direction of the drift.

Ellen White writes in *Steps to Christ*: the disciples of Christ "behold the Saviour's matchless love... and to them duty becomes a delight and sacrifice a pleasure." First love produces that. When the center holds — when the eye has not grown dim — the work flows from love rather than replacing it.

That is available to you.

Not because you have earned the return. Not because you have perfected the discipline. Because Christ is still at the door. Still knocking. Still asking the question He asked Peter on the shore.

[Final close — slow, deliberate:]

Luke stayed. So can you.

Not in your own strength. In the strength of the One who stayed for you.

Go love Him first.

Close in prayer. Not for success or a better week — for reordered love.

QUICK-REFERENCE TIMING CARD

| Section | Key Line | Time | |---|---|---| | Opening | "One drifted. One stayed." | 3 min | | Biblical Ground | Three mentions; *agape* as Greek | 5 min | | Anatomy of Drift | Three symptoms; physician metaphor | 8 min | | Anatomy of Fidelity | Three Luke anchors; "only" | 7 min | | Interior Turn | Personal testimony; "where is your love?" | 4 min | | Prescription / Close | Remember, Repent, Return; final kicker | 3 min | | **TOTAL** | | **30 min** |

KEY SCRIPTURES (have these marked)

- Philemon 1:24
- Colossians 4:14
- 2 Timothy 4:10–11
- Revelation 2:4–5
- John 21:15–17
- Luke 9:23

EGW QUOTES (have these ready)

- *Acts of the Apostles*, p. 455 — Demas's "shortsighted exchange"
- *Acts of the Apostles*, p. 490 — Luke's comfort to Paul
- *Testimonies*, Vol. 5, p. 161 — absorbed in business
- *Steps to Christ*, p. 44 — duty becomes delight

STACCATO KICKERS (know these cold)

1. "One drifted. One stayed. The difference is the whole sermon." 2. "The most dangerous spiritual condition is not rebellion. It is comfortable productivity with a cold heart." 3. "Only Luke is with me. Three words. One lifetime of faithfulness compressed." 4. "Luke stayed. So can you. Not in your own strength. In the strength of the One who stayed for you."